The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

17th January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Rendezvous (मिलन स्थल)

Meaning: A planned meeting or assembly, especially in a specific location.
Synonyms: Meeting, encounter, assembly
Example: The astronauts prepared for their orbital rendezvous with the space station.

2. Abortive (असफल)

Meaning: Failing to achieve the intended purpose; unsuccessful.
Synonyms: Unsuccessful, futile, failed
Antonyms: Successful, effective, fruitful
Example: The project was declared abortive after the team failed to meet the deadline.

VOCABULARY

3. Lucrative (लाभदायक)

Meaning: Producing a great deal of profit or financial gain.
Synonyms: Profitable, rewarding, advantageous
Antonyms: Unprofitable, unproductive, loss-making
Example: Space tourism is expected to be a lucrative industry in the future.

4. Perceived (अनुभूत)

Meaning: Become aware of or recognize something.
Synonyms: Recognized, understood, discerned
Antonyms: Ignored, overlooked, disregarded
Example: The new policy was perceived as unfair by the public.

VOCABULARY

5. Inevitable (अनिवार्य)

Meaning: Certain to happen; unavoidable.
Synonyms: Unavoidable, certain, inescapable
Antonyms: Avoidable, uncertain, preventable
Example: Technological advancements are inevitable in the modern world.

6. Acquittal (दोषमुक्ति)

Meaning: A judgment that a person is not guilty of the crime they were charged with.
Synonyms: Exoneration, clearance, absolution
Antonyms: Conviction, sentencing, blame
Example: The defendant celebrated his acquittal after months of trial.

VOCABULARY

7. Bane (अभिशाप)

Meaning: A cause of great distress or annoyance.
Synonyms: Curse, burden, affliction
Antonyms: Blessing, boon, benefit
Example: Traffic congestion is the bane of urban living.

8. Stepping Stone (सीढ़ी का पत्थर)

Meaning: An action or event that helps one progress toward a goal.
Synonyms: Milestone, foundation, aid
Antonyms: Obstacle, hindrance, barrier
Example: Completing the internship was a stepping stone to her successful career.

VOCABULARY

9. Ex Ante (पूर्व प्रत्याशित)

Meaning: Based on forecasts or predictions rather than actual results.
Synonyms: Predictive, projected, preemptive
Antonyms: Ex post, retrospective
Example: The company's strategy was devised with ex anaaaaaaaate assumptions about market trends.

10. Adrift (भटकता हुआ)

Meaning: Lacking direction, purpose, or control.
Synonyms: Lost, aimless, wandering
Antonyms: Anchored, stable, directed
Example: The sailor found himself adrift in the vast ocean after losing his compass.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Catch up on
Meaning - to do something you missed or fell behind on.

2. Cheer on
Meaning - to encourage someone.

3. Come forward
Meaning - to volunteer information or help.

4. Ease into
Meaning - to approach or enter something gradually.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Grease the palm

Meaning: to bribe discreetly to gain favours

2. Turn a deaf ear

Meaning: to ignore someone when they complain or ask for something

3. In a flutter

Meaning: to be in a state of confusion or excitement

VOCABULARY

4. At a loose end

Meaning: not knowing what to do

5. Blow hot and cold

Meaning: keep changing their attitude towards something

Article for Reading

Gates in the sky: On ISRO and SpaDeX

On December 30, 2024, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) launched its PSLV-C60 mission. Its primary payload was a pair of satellites for the Space Docking Experiment, or SpaDeX, to demonstrate orbital rendezvous and docking. The ability to execute it in orbit is an essential stepping stone to more complex missions. The launch was also hailed as ISRO ending the year on a high, but SpaDeX reminded us that sophisticated spaceflight missions care little for arbitrary deadlines. The satellites successfully docked on January 16 after a few abortive attempts. They were expected to dock on January 7, which ISRO postponed to January 9, then brought them close without docking on January 12 in an apparent data-taking effort. It nixed the January 9 attempt after the satellites were found to have drifted more than expected, prompting measures to arrest the displacement and reinitialise the experiment. Once docked, ISRO began tests to verify if the satellites could exchange electric power, then undock and separate, followed by testing their own payloads that would be spread over two years.

The C60 mission also launched the fourth stage of the rocket as an orbital platform. It carried 24 payloads from various ISRO centres and private enterprises testing various technologies. The Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre's Compact Research module for Orbital Plant Studies was able to have cowpea seeds germinate in orbit, capturing the popular imagination. Docking allows spacefaring components to be launched separately and assembled in space to form a larger module. This allows a space agency to plan interplanetary missions whose spacecraft are heavier than what the heaviest rockets can launch. Docking is thus a symbolic gateway to new opportunities, with the Chandrayaan-4 lunar sample return mission being a good example. In anticipation, ISRO loaded the SpaDeX satellites with enough fuel for multiple tries and also continuously collected data. Its own nervousness became evident, too: after the first two attempts, it backed down from its promise to live-stream the successful one.

Docking technology has become desirable thanks to the perceived inevitability of long-duration spaceflight. The pressure to lower costs imposed by, say, crewed missions to Mars or space-mining operations has rendered ideas such as in-space satellite servicing and orbital resupply platforms, both of which require docking, more lucrative. ISRO plans to start launching the 'Bharatiya Antariksh Station' (BAS) later this decade. As it embarks on a new phase of operations, with V. Narayanan as its new chairman, ISRO should also describe a coherent vision for the ex ante utility expected of BAS. Without this context, the larger pieces of the Indian space programme and their purpose relative to other countries' plans seem adrift.

Summary

On December 30, 2024, ISRO launched the PSLV-C60 mission, carrying satellites for the Space Docking Experiment (SpaDeX) to demonstrate orbital rendezvous and docking, a key capability for complex space missions. After some challenges and adjustments, the satellites successfully docked on January 16, 2025. Post-docking tests included power exchange, undocking, and payload operations to be conducted over two years. Additionally, the mission launched the rocket’s fourth stage as an orbital platform with 24 payloads, including a successful experiment on cowpea seed germination in orbit. Docking technology enables modular assembly of spacecraft for heavier interplanetary missions, exemplified by ISRO's Chandrayaan-4 lunar sample return mission. It also holds promise for future applications like orbital resupply and satellite servicing, crucial for long-duration spaceflight. ISRO plans to develop the Bharatiya Antariksh Station (BAS) later this decade but needs to define its vision and relevance to global space efforts under its new chairman, V. Narayanan.

The tone of the passage is informative and analytical, reflecting on ISRO’s achievements and challenges in the PSLV-C60 mission, while emphasizing the significance of docking technology and the need for a coherent vision for India’s space program in the global context.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
Why did ISRO postpone the initial docking attempts during the SpaDeX mission?

a) Technical failures in the PSLV-C60 rocket.
b) Drift in satellite positioning beyond acceptable limits.
c) Fuel shortages in the SpaDeX satellites.
d) The need to prioritize other payloads onboard the PSLV-C60 mission.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
What challenge did ISRO face after the first two SpaDeX attempts, according to the passage?

a) A shortage of public funding for live-streaming future docking events.
b) Public criticism for the lack of transparency in their operations.
c) The satellites' inability to exchange electric power during docking.
d) A decision to refrain from live-streaming the successful docking attempt.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What does the passage suggest about ISRO's plans for the Bharatiya Antariksh Station (BAS)?

a) BAS will primarily focus on long-duration human spaceflight missions.
b) BAS will serve as India's answer to space mining challenges.
c) ISRO needs to define the practical utility of BAS in a global context.
d) BAS will enable more frequent launches of reusable satellites.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

Open era: On the Australian Open

Coming as it does at the beginning of a brand new tennis season, the Australian Open is never short of fresh and intriguing storylines. The 2025 edition, which started on Sunday, is no exception. Of interest will be Novak Djokovic's quest for a record-breaking 25th Major, Jannik Sinner's title defence amidst a doping cloud, Carlos Alcaraz's search for a maiden trophy in Melbourne and Aryna Sabalenka's desire to make it a hat-trick Down Under. With his greatest rivals Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal retired, Djokovic is the lone representative from the Big Three era. The 37-year-old, a record 10-time champion in Australia, has not won an ATP Tour-level title since November 2023 and will be looking to three-time Slam winner Andy Murray, who is now his coach, for some fresh solutions as he enters the last leg of his career.

Sinner, who had an otherwise impeccable 2024, awaits an April hearing at the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS) after the World Anti-Doping Agency appealed his acquittal by the International Tennis Integrity Agency (ITIA) over two failed dope tests. Alcaraz, at 21, can become the youngest man to win a career Grand Slam (acquiring all four Majors at least once) while Sabalenka, with her fourth Slam, can cement her position as the best hard-court player in the world. With Sinner and Alcaraz having split 2024's Majors equally, the onus was on Alexander Zverev and Daniil Medvedev to ensure that their generation — sandwiched between the times of the Big Three and the Sinner-Alcaraz duopoly — is not squeezed out in tennis' all-new era. But Medvedev lost on Thursday, leaving Zverev with the responsibility of maintaining their position at the high table. Though the rungs are not as clear cut among women, there is intense jostling at the top among the trinity of Sabalenka, Iga Swiatek and Coco Gauff.

Swiatek is a five-time Slam champion but has gone past the fourth round at Melbourne Park just once (2022, semifinal). The 23-year-old also has her aura dimmed after accepting a month's ban in November for a positive dope test. For the United States' Gauff, a lack of consistency has been her bane. But if she can carry her strong recent form — WTA Finals crown in November 2024 and United Cup triumph earlier this January — she will be a real force. Unfortunately, Indians are never part of these conversations. Sumit Nagal is already out, losing in the first round, and so are men's doubles practitioners Rohan Bopanna — who at the 2024 Australian Open became the oldest man to be No.1 and win a Major — and Yuki Bhambri.

Question 4:
Why is Aryna Sabalenka's performance closely watched at the 2025 Australian Open?

a) She has won the tournament three consecutive times and seeks a fourth title.
b) She aims to solidify her reputation as the best hard-court player with a third consecutive Australian Open win.
c) She faces tough competition from Swiatek and Gauff for her first hard-court title.
d) She is returning from a doping ban imposed in November 2024.
e) None of the above

Question 5:
What challenge does the “sandwiched” generation of Zverev and Medvedev face in the 2025 Australian Open?

a) Dominating the tournament against the Big Three.
b) Competing against players with doping allegations.
c) Proving their relevance between the Big Three and Sinner-Alcaraz eras.
d) Surpassing their previous achievements at Melbourne Park.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Precis Writing.

Original Text

The development of a country is a multifaceted process influenced by various interconnected factors. Economic growth is often regarded as a key driver, as it creates jobs, boosts industries, and improves living standards. A strong economy provides the resources needed for infrastructure development, healthcare, education, and technological advancement, all of which contribute significantly to a nation’s progress. However, economic growth alone is insufficient. Education plays a critical role in empowering citizens with knowledge and skills, fostering innovation, and driving social mobility. Similarly, healthcare systems are vital for ensuring a healthy workforce and

reducing disease burdens, which directly impact productivity. Infrastructure, including transportation, energy, and communication networks, is another essential factor that facilitates economic activities and connects people and markets. Governance and political stability also play a crucial role in a country's development. Transparent policies, rule of law, and accountable leadership create an environment conducive to investment and innovation. Additionally, social equity and inclusion ensure that development benefits reach all segments of society, reducing poverty and inequality. Environmental sustainability is equally important, as unchecked exploitation of natural resources can hinder long-term growth. Thus, the development of a country depends on the harmonious integration of economic, social, political, and environmental factors.

- **Write an email to the Admission Officer of the Central college, asking him/her about the information on the admission process, fees, hostel facility, and eligibility criteria for your course.**

To: College@gmail.com

Subject: Inquiry Regarding Admission Process and Related Information

Dear [Admission Officer's Name],

I hope this email finds you well. I am writing to inquire about the admission process for the [specific course name, e.g., "Bachelor of Science in Computer Science"] at Central College. I am keen to understand the requirements and details to ensure I follow the proper steps for enrollment.

Specifically, I would like to request information on the following aspects:

Admission Process: Could you please share the key dates, required documents, and steps involved?
Fees Structure: I would appreciate it if you could provide a detailed breakdown of the tuition fees and any additional costs.

Hostel Facilities: Are there hostel accommodations available? If so, could you share details on room types, charges, and amenities?
Eligibility Criteria: What are the academic and other requirements for admission to this course?
I am eager to pursue my studies at Central College and look forward to your guidance. If there are any brochures or links to the relevant sections of your website, please share them.

Thank you for your time and assistance. I look forward to your response.

Warm regards,
[Your Full Name]
[Your Contact Information]

Match the column

1. Grease the palm	A. to ignore someone
2. Turn a deaf ear	B. to bribe
3. In a flutter	C. to be in a state of confusion or excitement
4. At a loose end	D. keep changing their attitude towards something
5. Blow hot and cold	E. not knowing what to do

Answer:

1-b

2-a

3-c

4-e

5-d

Vocabulary

1. Rendezvous:
2. Abortive:
3. Lucrative:
4. Perceived:
5. Inevitable:
6. Acquittal:
7. Bane:
8. Stepping Stone:
9. Ex Ante:
10. Adrift:

Rc ans

1.

Ans: b

Explanation:

ISRO postponed the initial docking attempt after detecting unexpected drift in satellite positions, requiring corrective measures and reinitialization of the experiment.

Reference:

“It nixed the January 9 attempt after the satellites were found to have drifted more than expected, prompting measures to arrest the displacement and reinitialise the experiment.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) There is no mention of technical failures in the PSLV-C60 rocket.

c) The satellites were loaded with sufficient fuel for multiple attempts, so fuel shortages were not an issue.

d) The delays were specific to SpaDeX, not due to prioritizing other payloads.

2.

Ans: d

Explanation:

ISRO decided not to live-stream the final successful docking attempt after challenges during the first two attempts, likely reflecting caution due to prior difficulties.

Reference:

“Its own nervousness became evident, too: after the first two attempts, it backed down from its promise to live-stream the successful one.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) There is no mention of funding issues impacting live-streaming.
b) Public criticism for transparency is not addressed in the passage.
c) The issue was not related to electric power exchange; this was tested post-docking.

3.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage suggests that ISRO should articulate a clear vision for the expected utility of BAS to ensure its alignment with global space exploration efforts.

Reference:

“As it embarks on a new phase of operations, with V. Narayanan as its new chairman, ISRO should also describe a coherent vision for the ex ante utility expected of BAS.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) Long-duration missions are not explicitly stated as BAS’s focus.
b) Space mining is mentioned as a driver for docking but is not linked to BAS.
d) Reusable satellites are not discussed in relation to BAS.

4.

Ans: b

Explanation:

Sabalenka, already with two consecutive Australian Open titles, is seeking a third to establish herself as the best hard-court player.

Reference:

“Aryna Sabalenka’s desire to make it a hat-trick Down Under… can cement her position as the best hard-court player in the world.”

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) She seeks a third title, not a fourth.

c) Sabalenka is already recognized as a strong hard-court player and is not seeking her first title.

d) The doping ban reference applies to Swiatek, not Sabalenka.

5.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage explicitly discusses how Zverev and Medvedev's generation is caught between the dominance of the Big Three and the emerging Sinner-Alcaraz duopoly, struggling to assert their place.

Reference:

"The onus was on Alexander Zverev and Daniil Medvedev to ensure that their generation — sandwiched between the times of the Big Three and the Sinner-Alcaraz duopoly — is not squeezed out."

Why the other options are incorrect:

a) The Big Three era has largely ended, with only Djokovic remaining active.
b) Doping allegations are not linked to Zverev or Medvedev.
d) Previous achievements at Melbourne Park are not discussed as a specific challenge.

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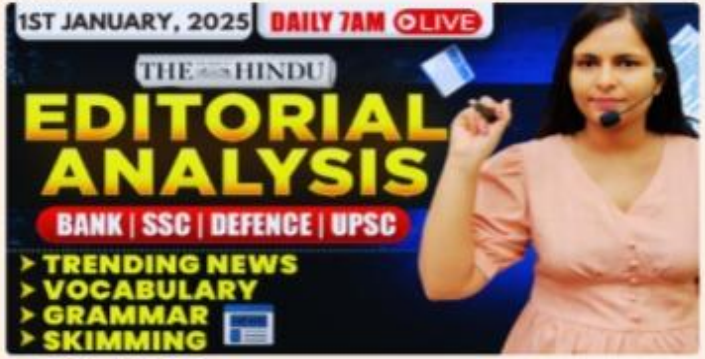

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